



LIBRA UNVEILED

054 / 18 JUN 2019 / FACEBOOK / COMMON

A NEW GLOBAL CURRENCY.

On 18 June 2019, Facebook unveiled plans for Libra, a digital currency intended to make sending money across borders easier. Its new subsidiary, Calibra, was developing a wallet for Messenger, WhatsApp and a standalone app. The announcement imagined payments reaching people already connected through their phones.

Libra was initially proposed as a currency backed by a reserve tied to a basket of national currencies, with oversight from an association. The ambition was stability and worldwide use. This was a proposed payment system, not a currency that had already launched.

That potential reach also brought scrutiny. Policymakers questioned how a private global payment network would protect users, handle personal data, prevent money laundering and affect financial stability. The same scale that made the idea compelling made its governance consequential.

The project changed direction and was renamed Diem in 2020. In January 2022, Diem announced the sale of its assets to Silvergate and began winding down. Libra never launched in the form presented in 2019, leaving the announcement as a moment of extraordinary ambition and unresolved questions.

The giant blue globe turns that ambition into a room-sized vision. A presenter explains it while two observers consider the proposal. The card phrase, A NEW GLOBAL CURRENCY., comes from Facebook's announcement. This imagined demonstration captures the promise and the scrutiny surrounding the idea.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE BLUE GLOBE

An oversized illuminated Earth gives physical form to Libra's worldwide ambition. Its scale is symbolic; the display is an invented presentation device.

02 THE LIBRA EMBLEM

Three wave-like lines and the Libra name identify the proposed project on the plinth. The emblem anchors the scene to the 2019 announcement.

03 THE PROJECT PAPER

The observer holds a document marked Project Libra. It represents a proposal under consideration, rather than an operational currency or a facsimile of a historical document.

04 THE OBSERVERS

The thoughtful figures suggest questions about trust and governance. Blue light connects them to the globe; their identities and this meeting are fictional.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: Facebook: Introducing Calibra; Federal Reserve: Digital Currencies; Diem: Asset Sale Statement. The demonstration room, globe display and people are fictional visual interpretation, not a documented launch photograph.